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The Quality of Salesperson-Manager Relationship: The Effect of Latitude, Loyalty and Competence

Susan K. DelVecchio

Leader-Member Exchange theory proposes *both* the salesperson and manager make contributions to their working relationship. Effective leadership is dependent upon developing a high quality relationship. This study tests the proposals of Leader-Member Exchange by examining the exchange of manager contributions (allowing the salesperson more operating freedom or latitude) and those of the salesperson. While the receipt of managerial latitude has a direct effect on the salesperson's evaluation of the working relationship, the salesperson's contributions also play a part. The manager allows more latitude to salespeople who are seen as more competent and loyal. These exchanges (latitude for competency and loyalty) and the quality of the salesperson-manager relationship may be especially important when the sales task requires adaptive selling behaviors.

Introduction

The Leader-Member Exchange (LMX) theory of leadership promises to be a useful tool for sales managers. Using the concepts from this leadership theory, sales managers can improve working relationships and job-related outcomes. Outcomes such as reduced stress, increased motivation and increased job satisfaction have been associated with the quality of the salesperson-manager relationship (Lagace 1990; Lagace, Castleberry and Ridnour 1993; Lapidus, Roberts and Chonko 1997; Tanner, Dunn and Chonko 1993). To fully realize the promise offered by LMX theory, however, problems concerning the outcomes of LMX as well as the measurement of LMX must first be addressed.

While studies to date have established a link between LMX and the subordinate's feelings, few studies have examined outcomes which describe actual job performance. Studies indicate the salesperson's feelings about his or her manager are closely tied to the salesperson's feelings of stress or satisfaction (Lagace 1990; Lagace, Castleberry and Ridnour 1993; Tanner and Castleberry 1990; Tanner, Dunn and Chonko 1993; Yammarino and Dubinsky 1992).

A salesperson experiencing lower levels of role conflict and higher levels of satisfaction is not necessarily a more productive member of the sales force (Brown and Peterson 1993). While studies have found a link between LMX and these affective job-related outcomes, no such consistent link has been established between some affective job-related outcomes and performance. More research is needed to examine the degree to which LMX influences actual sales behaviors and performance.

In addition, problems concerning the LMX measure must be addressed. Precisely what is being measured in the popular seven-item LMX scale is an issue of debate and controversy (Graen and Uhl-Bien 1995). This scale falls short of reflecting adequately the complex nature of the salesperson-manager relationship (Tanner and Castleberry 1990). Critics of LMX have called for studies which provide both conceptual and empirical support for the LMX measure (Dienesch and Liden 1986; Vecchio and Gobdel 1984).

Thus, the purposes of this study are twofold: (1) to address LMX measurement problems and (2) to examine the effect LMX has on sales productivity. A detailed description of the LMX measurement problems is presented and solutions to these problems are proposed. In addition, the proposed model of LMX extends the applicability of this leadership theory by examining the effect LMX has on adaptive selling behaviors and sales performance.

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LMX Measurement: Problems and Proposed Solutions

The most widely used seven-item scale (measuring LMX) makes no distinction between *what* is being exchanged and the *quality* level of the relationship (Dienesch and Liden 1986).¹ A problem arises when studies examine the link between LMX and these contributions. Past studies have explored the link between LMX and contributions such as trust, support, loyalty, and recognition. The LMX measure includes items which are closely related to these contributions. Frequently, scales measuring these two concepts share similar items. Table 1 provides a description of six examples from previous studies. The amount of shared variances in these studies may be attributable item redundancy, and conclusions about causation may be compromised.

The solution proposed and tested in this study, therefore, is to separate these concepts: *contributions* to the relationship and the *evaluation* of the working relationship. While these concepts are separate, they clearly are related. According to LMX and social exchange theory, the evaluations of the working relationship are dependent upon that which has been exchanged. From its inception, LMX has focused on the resources managers differentially gave each subordinate. Graen and Cashman (1975) measured the degree of managerial latitude given to each subordinate using three perspectives (i.e., the manager, the subordinate and peer reports). Dansereau, Graen and Haga (1975) used multiple informants and repeated measures in a longitudinal field study. Using these exacting methods, both studies found managers offered different levels of support and information to each subordinate.

Many adjectives were used to label these differences (such as "in-group" versus "out-group," "cadre" versus "hired-hand"). All of these adjectives were describing the same results: levels of exchanged resources between the leader and member were the defining factor in relationship quality. Consistent with LMX and social exchange theory, therefore, the model of LMX proposed in this study describes the quality of relationship as dependent upon the exchange of leader and member resources.

The second problem with the LMX measure concerns the exchange of these contributions. The LMX measure *assumes* each dyad member is exchanging resources and do not explicitly test for an exchange

relationship. The 7-item LMX measure combines various contributions made to the exchange by each dyad member into one measure. As a result, researchers and managers lack insights concerning which contributions provide the basis for this exchange relationship. If the manager and subordinate understand what each party values in the exchange and what is being exchanged, then both the salesperson and manager can work effectively to improve the quality of the working relationship.

No study to date has explicitly tested the exchange of these contributions. The model proposed and tested here, therefore, measures each contribution separately and tests for a link between them. Figure 1 provides an overview of these linkages. In this manner, the viability of the dyadic exchange premise, each contribution, as well as the quality of the relationship, can be evaluated.

LMX within the Field Sales Context

The salesperson-manager relationship must contend with the physical and psychological distances inherent in the boundary spanning context. In this context, the salesperson and manager develop a working relationship without the benefit of frequent face-to-face contact. This distance and lack of frequent contact may affect which resource each dyad member values (Scandura 1996).

One managerial resource, that of operating freedom or latitude, is a central and repeating theme in sales management research and boundary spanning literature. The "extent of supervision" (i.e., the amount and nature of sales manager direction) has been included in numerous published studies and the results subjected to meta-analyses (Brown and Peterson 1993; Churchill, Ford and Walker 1985). Recently the same variable has been studied from a sales force control systems perspective (Oliver and Anderson 1994).

Boundary spanning role theory examines managerial latitude as part of a cycle of behaviors (Adams 1976). This cycle of behaviors claims that the behavior of one dyad member is affected by the other. This cycle is based on the exchange of valued resources or contributions (Graen and Cashman 1975). The value the manager places on these contributions is affected by the boundary spanning context of the field sales setting (Scandura 1996).

Lacking the ability to frequently directly observe the salesperson's performance, managers place a

Table 1
Examples of Redundancy: Past LMX Studies

<i>Item in 7-item LMX Scale^a</i>	<i>Item similar to concept</i>	<i>Concept Description (or sample items):</i>	<i>Study which explored concept & LMX</i>	<i>Conclusion of study</i>
1. Manager will bail out subordinate.	Support	The degree of manager support in the face of a crisis. Mgr. help overcoming obstacles. Degree to which mgr. makes resources available to deal with problems.	Ballentine, Nunns & Brown 1992	LMX shares a significant correlation with support.
2. Subordinate will defend and justify manager's decisions.	Loyalty	Gives public support for other dyad member. In absence of manager, will defend mgr's decisions to others.	Wilhelm, Herd & Steiner 1993	LMX moderates the effect of subordinate loyalty on managerial attributions.
3. Manager will use personal power to help subordinate.	Trust	The degree to which you can rely on another person's behavior.	Lagace 1990	Higher LMX dyads include a salesperson who is more trusting.
4. Subordinate knows where he/she stands with manager.	Feedback Inquiry	The frequency with which the subordinate asked manager for information concerning his/her progress, evaluation and/or performance.	Vancouver & Morrison 1995	LMX shared a significant amount of variation with feedback inquiry.
5. Manager understands subordinates' needs and problems.	Management awareness and concern	Manager is aware of the needs of the subordinate. Manager is concerned with the problems encountered by the subordinates.	Kozlowski & Doherty 1989	Significant differences in high and low dyads in terms of management awareness and concern.
6. Manager recognizes subordinates' potential.	Recognition	Subordinate's actions are appropriately recognized by manager. Subordinate's behaviors are appropriately recognized by manager.	Dunegan, Tierney & Duchon 1992	Low LMX dyads report lower recognition from managers.

^a The seventh item is "the degree to which the working relationship is effective."

**. . . the salesperson and manager develop a working
relationship without the benefit of frequent
face-to-face contact.**

high value on subordinates who do not require close monitoring (Frey and Adams 1972). Close monitoring puts a strain on the limited resources (such as time) available to any manager. When a subordinate eases the strain on those limited resources, he or she is a valued asset to the manager (Wakabayashi, Graen and Uhl-Bien 1990). A competent or loyal salesperson proves to be just such an asset. The more competent or loyal "boundary spanner" executes assigned tasks effectively and in a manner endorsed by the manager (Adams 1976). A competent salesperson does not require detailed directives. A loyal salesperson's behavior is, from the viewpoint of the manager, more predictable and reliable. Thus, salesperson loyalty and competence are exchanged for managerial latitude. Latitude, loyalty and competence provide the currency for this exchange salesperson-manager relationship. The subsequent sections address each of these contributions (managerial latitude, salesperson competence and salesperson loyalty), the quality of relationship and, finally, the outcomes associated with higher quality relationships.

Latitude, Loyalty and Competence as Contributions

Managerial latitude has been defined as the amount of freedom and autonomy granted informally by the manager (Graen and Cashman 1975). Salespeople have a strong preference for managerial styles characterized by autonomy (Hite and Bellizzi 1986). The subordinate-superior relationship experiences lower levels of dyadic problems when the subordinate is given higher levels of latitude (Keller and Dansereau 1995). Results from prior studies (using measures of operational autonomy or participative decision-making) suggest managers in high quality dyadic exchanges offer higher levels of latitude (Dunegan, Tierney and Duchon 1992; Strutton and Pelton 1994).

Hypothesis 1: The salesperson-manager relationship quality is positively related to sales manager-granted latitude.

Loyalty has been defined as the expression of public support for the goals and personal character of the manager (Dienesch 1987; Graen and Scandura 1987). The link between loyalty and the overall working relationship has been explored from the managerial viewpoint. Relying solely on the viewpoint of the leader, findings of previous studies have found leaders often develop dependent and crucial relationships with the most loyal subordinates (Graen and Cashman 1975).

By definition, a loyal salesperson supports the manager and values his or her association with the manager (Withey and Cooper 1992). If the salesperson-manager relationship is described as a highly valued one, then the subordinate is more likely to feel his or her investment of loyalty is justified (Gregersen 1993; Wilhelm, Herd and Stiener 1993). One form of justification may be the receipt of higher levels of latitude. Under these circumstances (i.e., a high quality working relationship), salesperson loyalty and managerial latitude are part of this dyadic exchange.

Hypothesis 2: The salesperson-manager relationship quality is positively related to salesperson loyalty.

Managers (subjects) are more likely to engage in higher quality working relationships with subordinates who are described as highly competent (Kim and Organ 1982). Results from longitudinal studies support these findings. Managers in non-sales work settings tend to develop higher quality working relationships early in the careers of competent subordinates (Duchon, Green and Taber 1986; Liden, Wayne and Stilwell 1993; Wakabayashi, Graen and Uhl-Bien 1990). To what extent the salesperson shares these perceptions remains unexplored.

Hypothesis 3: The salesperson-manager relationship quality is positively related to salesperson competence.

The relationship between a salesperson's level of competence and his or her loyalty to has been viewed as both a complementary as well as compensatory one. A competent salesperson may feel because of his or her abilities that he or she is less dependent upon the manager, feels no need to support the manager and may act, as a result, less loyal. Research in non-sales settings found less competent workers express more loyalty toward their employers. White collar workers in an electronics laboratory who were less competent felt more loyalty toward their employer's organization (Rotundi 1972). According to this viewpoint, lower levels of competency are compensated for by higher levels of loyalty.

This compensatory argument implies the competent salesperson would engage in behaviors described as disloyal (such as criticizing the sales manager during the sales calls). Buyers and sales managers alike may view this behavior as unprofessional, unethical, or lacking integrity (Lagace, Dahlstrom and Gassenheimer 1991). The ethics scale of the Lagace, Dahlstrom and Gassenheimer (1991) study alludes to this type of behavior (i.e., scale item #9). These behaviors may erode the salesperson's credibility and trustworthiness (Smith and Barclay 1997). Since trust is an important issue for industrial buyers, the salesperson's actual effectiveness and the manager's perceptions of salesperson competence may suffer (Doney and Cannon 1997). From this perspective, a competent salesperson would behave in a manner which is supportive of his or her manager.

Evidence from studies which explore manager-subordinate dyads supports the importance of elevated levels of *both* competence and loyalty in relationship-building activities (Schindler and Thomas 1992). Managers tend to trust the more competent and loyal subordinates and build closer relationships with them (Deluga 1994). Thus, the hypothesized relationship between salesperson competence and loyalty is a complementary one.

Hypothesis 4: Salesperson competence is positively related to salesperson loyalty.

Exchanges of Contributions

The sales manager does not allow all salespeople the same level of operating freedom or latitude

(DelVecchio 1996). The sales manager makes some judgments about each salesperson in an attempt to make the most of the freedom given to each salesperson. Further, the sales manager is making those judgments *before* the salesperson produces successful results. Longitudinal studies indicate managerial latitude is established fairly early in the vertical relationship (Dansereau, Graen and Haga 1975). Since managers are responsible for achieving sales goals, they seek to minimize the risk inherent in giving more freedom to subordinates by using discretion (Adams 1976; Frey and Adams 1972). This discretionary use of latitude may be based on two salesperson characteristics: loyalty and competence.

By definition, loyal salespeople defend and support their managers' interests. Since the loyal salesperson supports the manager's goals, the manager may more readily predict supportive behavior. This increased predictability reduces the risks incurred by allowing latitude (Adams 1976). From a social exchange perspective, then, salesperson loyalty is exchanged for managerial latitude.

Hypothesis 5: Salesperson loyalty is positively related to sales manager-granted latitude.

Managerial latitude and subordinate competence have been described as rewards or valued contributions, and as a result, these contributions influence the behaviors of dyad members (Graen and Scandura 1987). Latitude may be valued by the salesperson because it allows that individual flexibility when interacting with buyers and provides opportunities for job enrichment (Teas, Wacker and Hughes 1979). Just as managerial latitude is valued by the salesperson, competence is valued by the manager. LMX studies describe competency as "respect for the capabilities of the other dyad member" or as the "ability of the other dyad member to perform the job well" (Graen and Uhl-Bien 1995; Schriesheim, Neider, Scandura and Tepper 1992).

Since the manager, in part, is evaluated on meeting sales goals, the more competent salesperson may be seen as instrumental in accomplishment of those goals. There is some support for the notion that the sales manager's contribution of latitude may be influenced by the salesperson's competency levels. Literature reviewing the practice of participatory decision making suggests subordinate competence is one important contextual factor (Cotton et al. 1989). Managerial granted latitude, as defined in the Cotton, et al. (1989) study, represents one dimension of participatory decision making.

The sales manager does not allow all salespeople the same level of operating freedom or latitude . . .

Latitude is an informal form of participation which is based on the interactions between employee and his or her immediate supervisor.

Hypothesis 6: Salesperson competence is positively related to sales manager-granted latitude.

Sales Outcomes

Decades of leadership research have led us to conclude that effective outcomes are not dependent on one best style of leadership (Butler and Reese 1991; Graen and Uhl-Bien 1995). Thus, it would not be realistic to expect that there is *one* managerial behavior which will have a direct and consistent effect on the salesperson's behaviors. The exchanges between *both* the manager and his or her subordinate, however, can have an influence. An important set of behaviors for a field salesperson include adaptive selling behaviors.

Adaptive selling behaviors require that a salesperson develop creative solutions and alter his or her communications for each customer. This behavior requires more skill, planning, preparation, time and attention on the part of the salesperson (Knowles, Grove and Keck 1994). If this investment of time, skill and attention is not supported by sales management, it is less likely to occur (Vink and Verbeke 1993).

The high quality working relationship the salesperson shares with his or her manager may provide just such support (O'Hara, Boles and Johnston 1991). The industrial salesperson must add value by uncovering and defining each customer's unique set of problems, then offering solutions. The salesperson must adapt to each customer, problem and situation in order to offer innovative solutions (Sujan, Weitz and Kumar 1994). The salesperson cannot always verify these adaptations with his or her manager before making them.

If the salesperson and manager do not have a good working relationship, it is likely the salesperson will feel the need to verify every adaptation. Lacking frequent face-to-face contact, this may not be possible and may inhibit adaptive selling behaviors (Spiro and Weitz 1990). Thus, a high quality

working relationship provides support for the salesperson in taking the chances inherent in adaptations.

Hypothesis 7: Higher levels of salesperson-manager relationship quality will be associated with higher levels of adaptive selling behaviors.

The degree to which the salesperson-manager relationship affects sales performance is unclear. Empirical evidence is mixed. Tanner and Castleberry (1990) found a significant relationship between LMX and global sales performance measures. While they also found marginal support for one objective measure, three additional measures were not related to LMX. Similarly, Lagace (1990) found that a salesperson's income (as a measure of a sales outcome) was not affected by the salesperson-manager exchange quality. These mixed findings may in part be due to some of the LMX measurement issues which have been discussed previously. If the LMX model proposed here addresses these problems, then the conceptual linkages between LMX and performance should be supported (i.e., provide evidence of nomological validity).

Both sales and non-sales researchers contend higher quality relationships should have a positive effect on productivity (Graen and Cashman 1975; Tanner and Castleberry 1986). The salesperson who enjoys a higher level of vertical exchange with his or her manager is more likely to exhibit higher levels of sales since he or she is assigned to the preferred territories and receives individualized training or other forms of support from the manager (Tanner and Castleberry 1986).

Hypothesis 8: Higher levels of salesperson-manager relationship will be associated with higher levels of salesperson performance.

Method

Sample

Previous research indicates that significant differences in LMX are associated with the type of selling task (O'Hara, Boles and Johnston 1991;

Table 2
Respondents' Profile
Number of Participating Firms = 47
Number of Complete Dyad Responses = 155

Participating Firms		
<i>Annual Revenues:</i>		
Less than \$50,000,000	42%	
\$50,000,000 to \$200,000,000	25%	
Over \$200,000,000	33%	
<i>Type of Manufacturer:</i>		
Consumer Non-durable	31%	
Consumer Durable products	22%	
Industrial Equipment	47%	
<i>Compensation Methods:</i>	Salesperson	Sales Manager
Straight Salary	10%	8%
Salary + Commission	46%	29%
Salary + Bonus	42%	63%
Respondents		
<i>Education</i>		
High School	9.7%	5.8%
Some College	31.0%	22.6%
Undergraduate Degree	51.0%	45.2%
Some Graduate work	5.3%	20.0%
Graduate Degree	2.6%	5.8%
<i>Experience</i>		
Total Sales Experience	16.07 yrs	17.9 yrs
Average (Std.Dev.)	(11.4)	(8.8)
Sales Experience w/Current Firm	9.77 yrs	12.2 yrs
	(8.4)	(7.5)

Yammarino and Dubinsky 1992). The sample frame, therefore, was restricted to business-to-business field salespeople employed by manufacturing firms. *Thomas' Directory of Manufacturers* was used to generate a random sample of firms. Out of this sample, a total of fifty-two manufacturing firms agreed to participate. Responses were received for 47 out of the total 52 firms. These firms varied in terms of type of product manufactured as well as size of firm (as indicated by annual revenues). Table 2 provides a profile of these firms as well as the individual respondents.

Each participating firm provided addresses and reporting responsibilities for their sales force. Cover letters and surveys were sent to 270 selected salesperson-manager dyads. The selection of dyads was based on the number of salespeople reporting to each manager. Surveys were sent to a randomly selected portion (25%) of the salespeople reporting to any one manager.

The sales manager survey requested responses which described the salesperson named on the front of the questionnaire. The salespersons' version was numerically coded to facilitate the matching of sales-

person to manager responses. A complete and usable observation was one in which matched responses were received from both the manager and his or her respective salesperson.

Responses were received from 155 salespeople and their respective managers. Since surveys were sent to a total of 270 dyads, the effective response rate is 57.4%. For purposes of testing dyadic relationships, these 155 matched responses were considered complete observations. In addition to these complete (or matched) responses, 42 salespeople responded, but their sales managers did not. Similarly, 41 manager responses were received for which there were no subordinate responses. For purposes of testing non-response bias, therefore, the matched responses were compared to those of the unmatched (e.g., the t-statistic comparing the 41 unmatched responses to the 155 matched responses' loyalty levels was -1.07 with an associated p value of .2857). No significant differences were found between these two groups.

Measures

According to LMX and social exchange theory, both parties to this dyadic relationship offer contributions for that which they consider valuable. Since the manager values competency and loyalty in subordinates, it is the manager's assessment which is relevant. Similarly, since salespeople value managerial latitude, they responded to the latitude scale items. Table 3 summarizes the information concerning each measure.

Latitude was measured using the sum of the salesperson's responses to four Likert-type items adapted from Liden and Graen (1980). Adaptations to the original latitude scale included the deletion of items which related to loyalty. The original scale included items evaluating the degree to which each dyad member would defend and support the position of the other. Only those items which were consistent with the conceptual definition of latitude were retained. These items were subject to confirmatory factor analysis and results support an unidimensional structure. The $\chi^2_{(2)}$ was 3.9 with an associated p-value of .1471, indicating all four latitude items were tapping the same construct.

Loyalty was measured using a modified eight item scale (Atwater 1988; Dienesch 1987; Graen and Cashman 1975). Modifications to the loyalty scale were made to reflect the active forms of dyadic loy-

alty with a focus on the sales manager (Withey and Cooper 1992). This focus on the sales manager (and the unidimensionality it implies) was supported by the confirmatory factor analysis (nonsignificant $\chi^2_{(17)}$ with p-value of .2770).

Using the paradigm suggested by Churchill (1979), the development of perceived competence measure first sought to specify the domain of the construct. Competence has been defined as the quality of the work-oriented abilities (Dienesch 1987). In the sales management literature, these abilities have been described as those which help a salesperson work "smart" or solve complex problems (Weitz, Sujan and Sujan 1986). Working smart requires both a body of facts as well as the skills needed to use those facts (Sujan, Weitz and Kumar 1994). Declarative knowledge includes the facts associated with a category, such as attributes describing the customer, competitor and product. The skills needed to use these facts in the sales setting revolve around those used in persuasive communication.

With this conceptual framework in mind, an initial list of items was generated. In-depth interviews were conducted with first line sales managers from three manufacturing firms (building materials, machine tools and consumer package goods manufacturers). After editing, the list of items included three (declarative) knowledge and eight (procedural) skill items. The survey instrument used these eleven items to measure competency. Sales managers were asked to rate the competency level for each of these twelve items. Responses were provided on a seven-point scale with 7 rated as superior, 4 as average and 1 as inferior. Superior competency level was described on the questionnaire as "Competency level far exceeds expected, required or average levels." Average competency level was described as "average and at expected or required levels," and inferior was inadequate level of competency.

Four items were deleted from those measuring competency in skills (or procedures) based on both their factor loadings and content. Both content and factor loadings were used as criteria for deletion. Items with a loading of less than .36 were deleted (Stevens 1986). Two of the four deleted items were tangential to the selling tasks (e.g., decision making skills). Factor analysis was conducted on all (both matched with subordinate responses and unmatched) responses from sales managers (n=197). The reduced scale (using all three knowledge items

Table 3
Measures: Items, Respondents and Scales

<i>Variable</i>	<i>No. Of Items</i>	<i>Items</i>	<i>Respondent</i>	<i>Response Scale</i>	<i>Source</i>
Latitude	4	My manager is open to my suggestions regarding changes in my sales responsibilities. I think my sales manager is willing to listen to any and all suggestions I may have. As long as I keep my sales manager informed, I have plenty of operating freedom. I have freedom in the operation of my territory.	Salesperson	7 pt Likert	Liden & Graen 1980
Loyalty	8	This salesperson gives unwavering support to me when interacting with customers, even though he/she personally may not agree with me. This salesperson can be counted on to go along with my decisions on most occasions. This salesperson would generally be likely to give me credit for my ideas when talking to others. I can count on this person to give good reports about me to others. This salesperson adopts and supports my viewpoint regarding all business matters. This salesperson would not support my decisions. (Reverse score) This salesperson would be likely to criticize my work to other people without telling me that he or she was unhappy with it. (Reverse score) This salesperson would not support my decisions. (Reverse score) This salesperson tends to blame sales management for factors which affect his or her customers unfavorably.	Sales Manager	7 pt Likert	Graen & Cashman 1975
Competence	7	<i>Skills</i> Organizational skills Problem-Solving skills Written communication skills Verbal communication skills <i>Knowledge</i> Product knowledge Customer knowledge Competitive knowledge	Sales Manager	1=inferior to 7=superior level of competency	Study
Quality of Relationship	6	Friendly-Hostile Informal-Formal Close-Distant	Salesperson	7 pt scale between each pair	Vecchio & Gobdel 1984
Performance	3	Percent of quota achievement for three consecutive periods.	Sales Manager	% Achvmt	Study
Adaptive Selling Behaviors	16	Sample Items: Each customer requires a unique approach. I am very flexible in the selling approach I use. I use a set sales approach. (Reverse score)	Salesperson	7 pt Likert	Spiro & Weitz 1990

Sales managers should discuss the amount of latitude allowed the salesperson during the performance appraisal sessions.

and four skill items) was tested in the subsequent discriminant analysis (as well as the covariance analysis of the linear structural equations).

Discriminant validity of the competence measure was examined by comparing loyalty scale items to those of competence. Results from exploratory factor analysis were supportive. Loyalty items loaded on a separate factor from those of competence items. Similarly, the factor analysis of both the performance and competence items indicated these items measure different concepts. The correlations between performance and competence were, as expected, positive.

The quality of the relationship was evaluated using direct measures; questions which ask respondents to evaluate the overall working relationship. One of the items typically used in the seven-item LMX scale is just such a direct measure. (This item asks, "How effective is your working relationship with your leader?") Graen and Uhl-Bien (1995) refer to this item as the "centroid" of the Leader-Member Exchange, contending this item is the "most appropriate and recommended measure of LMX." Salespeople indicated the degree to which each anchor (in six sets of adjective pairs) described their working relationship with their sales manager.

The salesperson responded to sixteen items assessing the degree to which they engage in adaptive selling behaviors (Spiro and Weitz 1990). This scale has been tested on both homogeneous samples (Marks, Vorhies and Badovick 1996; Spiro and Weitz 1990) as well as heterogeneous samples (McIntyre, Wheatley and Uhr 1996; Swenson and Herchel 1994) and has demonstrated internal reliability between .87 and .85 (coefficient alphas). This scale measures the salesperson's beliefs about ways of dealing with the customer, how customers differ and how he or she behaves in the face of these differences (Marks, Vorhies and Badovick 1996).

A troublesome pattern in LMX studies is the contradiction across studies concerning the effect LMX has on objectively measured outcomes. When subjective measures are used, findings are in agree-

ment and converge. When objective measures are used, findings contradict each other (Vecchio, Griffeth and Hom 1986). This pattern is disconcerting in light of the work which explores the possible halo effect of a high LMX relationship (Duarte, Goodson and Klich 1994; Wilhelm, Herd and Steiner 1993). Subjective measures of performance are frequently provided by the manager. Those measures may be affected by the quality of the salesperson-manager relationship (Swift and Campbell 1995). To provide a stronger test of LMX, an objective measure of performance was used. The objective measure of performance was operationalized as the salesperson's percent of quota achievement for three sequential time periods.

Results

The internal reliability of the measures was assessed using the average pairwise correlation. See Table 4: Correlations and Coefficient Alphas. The coefficient alphas for all measures fell within acceptable ranges (Nunnally 1978). The variables tested in the full Covariance Analysis of Linear Structural Equations (CALIS) model were based on the summated scores. The lambda values for performance, adaptive selling behaviors, quality of relationship, latitude and loyalty (i.e., all of the scales which were unidimensional) were fixed at 1 minus their respective coefficient alphas.

The absolute fit indices provide support for the proposed model and indicate it is one plausible representation of the data. The p-value of the χ^2 statistic is .1829. This falls within the recommended conservative levels of .10 and .20. The goodness of fit and residuals imply the predicted and actual matrices are similar. The RMSEA value of .05 falls within the recommended range of .08 or less (Hair, Anderson, Tatham and Black 1995).

Incremental and parsimonious indices fall within acceptable ranges. Normed fit exceeds the .90 minimum at a value of .94. The comparison of the Null χ^2 to the proposed model χ^2 shows the proposed

Table 4
Correlations
(Coefficient Alpha on the Diagonal)

	<i>Avg.</i>	<i>Std. Dev</i>	<i>LAT</i>	<i>LOY</i>	<i>COMP-SKL</i>	<i>COMP-KNO</i>	<i>Q REL</i>	<i>PERF</i>	<i>ADAPT</i>
Latitude	23.5	4.5	(.85)						
Loyalty	43.4	7.2	.32	(.85)					
Competence-skill	20.6	4.2	.23	.24	(.87)				
Competence-knowledge	16.9	2.9	.29	.28	.59	(.86)			
Quality of Relationship	33.5	6.0	.65	.25	.19	.23	(.90)		
Performance	243	101	.07	0.00	.08	.18	.03	(.81)	
Adaptive Selling Behaviors	88.0	12.8	.27	-.03	.03	.02	.22	.18	(.86)

model provides an improved fit. In addition, the AGFI and GFI indices are both above the .90 level. Given the number of parameters estimated, this model provides an efficient explanation.

The critical sample size (n) for the proposed model marginally exceeds the minimal levels. The critical n is 203, and the minimum recommended value of 200 (Hoelter 1983; Wheaton 1987). The critical n was a concern since the correlation matrix is based on 155 observations. Marginal values of this singular indicator, however, are insufficient grounds for serious concern. To be conservative, however, a higher p -level is used in the subsequent section evaluating parameter estimates.

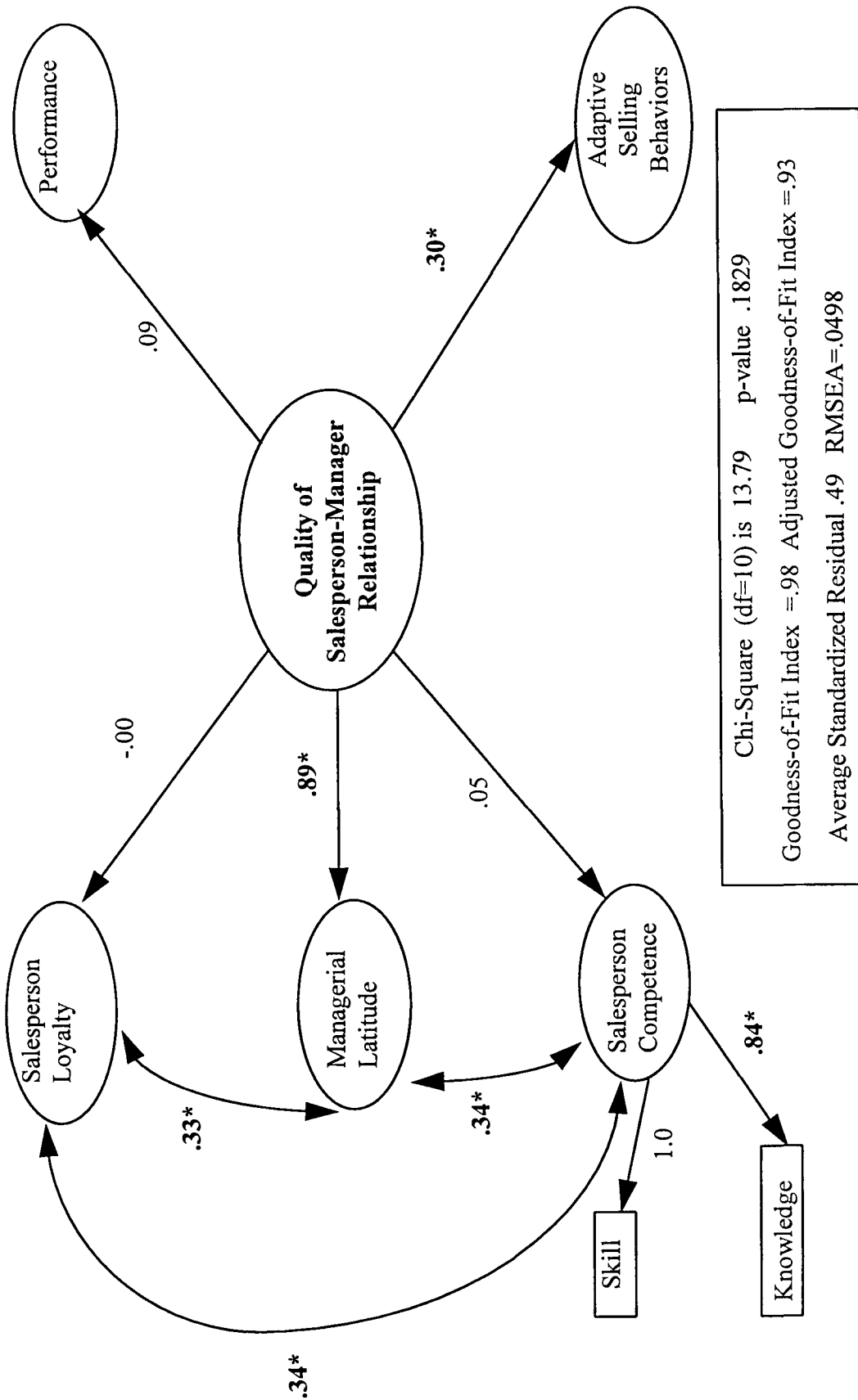
Consistent with the earlier LMX studies, latitude emerges as a major influence (standardized coefficient for $LAT \leftarrow QREL$ relationship was .98). It was interesting to note how much more important latitude was over the salesperson's contributions. The salesperson's competence and loyalty are not significant factors in explaining how the salesperson evaluated the relationship. The second and third hypotheses were not supported.

These two salesperson contributions (loyalty and competence) did, however, share a significant covariation with latitude. All of the ϕ parameter estimates indicate the contributions do co-vary with each other. The significant covariations among latitude, loyalty and competence provide support

for hypothesis four, five, and six. Further, these results support the notion of dyadic exchange. These significant covariations indicate the importance of the combined effect of latitude, loyalty and competence. While the quality of the relationship was largely a function of managerial latitude, the significant ϕ parameters imply salesperson loyalty and competence also have an influence. This influence is manifested in the ability of the model to explain a substantial variation in the quality of the working relationship.

The combination and configuration of variables in this model explained 82% of the variance in the quality of the relationship. Clearly the salesperson's perceptions are not influenced by only managerial latitude. A portion of the variation in these perceptions can be explained by the salesperson's competence and loyalty. This is an impressive finding given the fact that competence and loyalty were measured using the manager's responses. The significant covariations (i.e., ϕ parameters) indicate the sales manager's behaviors are part of the exchange nature of this relationship.

The extracted variance levels for the outcome variables were 1% for performance and 9% for adaptive selling behaviors. This same pattern is, of course, reflected in the estimated β values. H_7 was supported by these results but H_8 was not. The β for performance is not significant, but the β for adap-

Figure 1
Results

* Significant at the p-value of .01 or less.

Table 5
Parameter Estimates

<i>Parameter</i>	<i>Relationship</i>	<i>Standardized Coefficient</i>	<i>t-value</i>
λ_{11}	Skill $\leftarrow$ Comp	.70	4.28*
λ_{12}	Know $\leftarrow$ Comp	.84*	4.28*
Y_{11}	Qrel $\rightarrow$ Loy	0.00	-.05
Y_{12}	Qrel $\rightarrow$ Lat	.89*	9.36*
Y_{13}	Qrel $\rightarrow$ Comp	.05	.47
β_{11}	Qrel $\rightarrow$ Perf	.09	.99
β_{12}	Qrel $\rightarrow$ Adapt	.30*	3.29*
ϕ_{12}	Loy $\leftrightarrow$ Lat	.33*	3.77*
ϕ_{23}	Comp $\leftrightarrow$ Lat	.34*	3.02*
ϕ_{13}	Loy $\leftrightarrow$ Comp	.34*	3.02*

*Significant at the p-value of .01 or less.

tive selling behaviors is significant. The quality of relationship does have a significant effect on adaptive selling behaviors, but not on the overall achievement of sales quotas. The standardized parameter for the QREL $\rightarrow$ ADAPT relationship was .30 and .09 for performance.

Results concerning explained variances in adaptive selling behaviors were quite impressive since previous studies have been able to explain at most 6% (Levy and Sharma 1994). The behaviors of the salesperson (rather than the level of revenues generated) are influenced by the salesperson-manager relationship.

Modification indices and residuals were analyzed to test the plausibility of alternative models. Specifically, the possible improvements of a model which excludes the central concept (i.e., the quality of the salesperson-manager relationship) were tested. If the QREL concept was not useful, then the model would be improved by specifying direct relationships between each of the contributions (latitude, loyalty and competence) and outcomes (performance and adaptive selling). For example, Teas, Wacker and Hughes (1979) suggest there may be a direct link between latitude and adaptive selling behaviors. Some studies in sales management conclude that the sales manager has little effect on the independent and autonomous field salesperson. Only one of the modification indices (LaGrangian Multipliers) indicated this improvement. The salespersons' competence in knowledge levels was directly

related to quota achievement. No other contribution was directly related to outcomes.

This provides support for the importance of the relationship quality. Apparently the working relationship with the field sales manager does have an influence on selected salesperson job-related outcomes. The proposed model supports the notion that it is the salesperson-manager relationship (rather than the behaviors of the manager alone) which has an effect. This effect is more pronounced on the salesperson's behaviors than on the revenue level achieved in the sales territory.

Discussion

By separating and measuring the *contributions* to the relationship from the *evaluations* of the working relationship, this study uncovered three properties of Leader-Member Exchange Relationships: (1) differences in salesperson and manager contributions to the exchange relationship do exist, (2) these contributions share an exchange relationship, and (3) judgements about the quality of the dyadic relationship have an effect on adaptive selling behaviors.

First, not all contributions are equally important. Salespeople in this sample evaluate the relationship with his or her manager as of higher quality when he or she is the recipient of managerial latitude. This finding is consistent with prior research. Prior studies show a correlation between latitude

and dyadic problems was $-.47$ (Keller and Dansereau 1995), between autonomy and LMX was $.34$ (Dunegan, Tierney and Duchon 1992) and $.25$ between LMX and participative decision making (Klein and Snell 1994).

The salesperson's contributions (of competence and loyalty) do not have a direct effect on the salesperson's quality assessments. Apparently the salesperson is more influenced by what he or she receives (i.e., managerial latitude) rather than what he or she contributes (competence and loyalty levels).

Second, by separating the contributions, this study was able to explore the exchanges between salesperson and manager. The exchanges (of managerial latitude for salesperson competence and/or loyalty) do explain a substantial amount of variation in relationship quality. Competence and loyalty share a significant covariation with managerial latitude and, thus, explain a portion of the variance in the quality perceptions over and above that of latitude alone. When the salesperson receives high levels of latitude, his or her sales manager tends to rate this salesperson as highly competent and loyal. The competent salesperson is also seen as personally supportive of his or her manager. Given the fact that these contributions were measured using both dyad members' reports, these covariations are impressive and give credence to a leader-member exchange approach.

Further, the findings concerning the exchange of latitude for competence and loyalty may be useful in explaining some anomalies in the application of LMX theory to sales management. Swift and Campbell (1995) found that a sales manager tends to give less attention to high performing salespeople with whom he or she enjoys a good working relationship. When the relationship is of high quality, the manager may not feel a need to pay close attention (or may feel justified in allowing more latitude) to the more competent or loyal subordinate.

Finally, this study supports the importance of salesperson-manager relationship quality. Results suggest relationship quality is a viable central construct. The quality of the relationship is dependent upon the *contributions of* and *exchanges between* both dyad members. These quality assessments have a direct effect on selected sales outcomes. While relationship quality did not serve to improve quota achievement, it may foster increased levels of adaptive selling behaviors. The salesperson-man-

ager relationship may serve as a source of support to salespeople who are attempting to meet and adapt to the unique needs of each buyer.

Managerial Implications

If a salesperson were not engaging in adaptive selling behaviors, the first impulse of a manager may be to focus on the abilities or motivation of the under performing salesperson. This impulse is misplaced and adopts a narrow viewpoint of the problem. Sales managers who want to foster higher levels of adaptive selling behaviors should assess the quality of their working relationships. This assessment can be done by way of a formal survey using the measures tested in this study. As an alternative to a formal survey, sales managers can do this informally (such as during field time with the salesperson or during weekly communications). Either by way of informal discussions or formal surveys, managers can benefit from "taking the pulse" of their subordinates concerning the working relationship. The benefit, according to this study, is the increased likelihood that the salesperson will engage in adaptive selling behaviors.

Sales managers should discuss the amount of latitude allowed the salesperson during performance appraisal sessions. During a performance appraisal session, the discussion of latitude can be part of effective feedback. Effective feedback informs the salesperson of the impact or results his or her behavior has on buyers or on the manager. If a salesperson is the deserving recipient of higher levels of latitude, this should be emphasized. Higher levels of latitude are the reward for salesperson competence and loyalty.

Since the salesperson values his or her autonomy, the sales manager may want to clarify how and why they can increase it. In effect higher levels of latitude must be earned and helping the salesperson understand how he or she can achieve it will improve the working relationship. This may be done in training sessions (either informally, such as curbside coaching, or in more formal classroom settings). These training sessions can include a discussion of results of increased levels of sales competency and loyalty (i.e., more managerial latitude). Explaining the contingencies surrounding increased levels of managerial latitude may increase the salesperson's efforts in learning and mastering new skills and behaviors.

This study carries some implications for the salesperson as well as the manager. Achieving a high quality working relationship is not solely dependent on the behaviors of the manager. If a salesperson wants to improve his or her working relationships, he or she cannot be passive. Salespeople, as well as managers, should examine the effect their behaviors (or contributions) have on the other dyad member. More variability in outcomes was explained using this model which includes behaviors of both the manager and his or her subordinate. Achieving favorable outcomes may be less a matter of "one best style" as it is developing relationships.

Limitations and Future Research

This study explores both salesperson and manager contributions and finds support for an exchange model. From the salesperson's perspective, managerial latitude has a direct influence over relationship quality. The model can be expanded to explore other managerial contributions, such as support. When the sales manager allocates higher levels of latitude, does the manager also support that salesperson when problems arise—or does he or she allocate full responsibility for resolving problems as well? The interplay of these behaviors may affect how a salesperson feels about their working relationship. Other contributions of both the salesperson and manager may also be examined (such as access to information, expertise, trust, affect, etc.).

This study collected and matched responses from both the salesperson and manager. The sales manager's perception of salesperson contributions was combined with the salesperson's perceptions of managerial contributions. The quality of the relationship was measured using the salesperson's perspective, and *receiving* managerial latitude seems to dominate perceptions about the working relationship. Future research could test the quality perceptions of the sales manager. Perhaps a similar pattern would emerge and the manager would be more influenced by the *receipt* of resources than his or her own contributions.

While this sample included a diverse set of manufacturing firms, it does not include salespeople engaged in the sales of services alone. Previous studies exploring the link between selling-orientation and LMX have found significant linkages for industrial salespeople, but not for advertising salespeople (O'Hara, Boles and Johnston 1991). This study provides support for importance of LMX in indus-

trial sales, but not for other selling situations. The sample used for this study includes a diverse set of manufacturing firms, but not salespeople engaged in the sales of services alone. Results from these two studies imply the salesperson-manager relationship affects the salesperson's interactions with buyers more in some situations than others. Perhaps in service selling, the salesperson is more independent from the manager and more dependent upon the buyer-seller relationship. It would be interesting to examine the degree to which the selling task or context affects the importance of the salesperson-manager relationship.

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Endnote

- ¹The widely used 7-item LMX scale combines the one item which directly evaluates the quality of the dyadic relationship with the other items describing each dyad member's contributions to the relationship (e.g., loyalty, information or trust [Bhal and Ansari 1996; Schriesheim, Neider, Scandura and Tepper 1992]).